

Topic 6.1 - What continuing development is, and why it is not optional

A real classroom situation

	Continuing professional development	A training course	A qualification	An appraisal requirement
What it is for	Changing what happens in your classroom	Transferring content	Certifying a level	Satisfying a system that is watching
Who drives it	The teacher	The provider	The awarding body	The employer
How long it lasts	A career	Days	Years, then done	A cycle
What counts as success	Practice that changed, and pupils who noticed	Attendance	The award	The box ticked
What it cannot do	Happen to you without your participation	Make you use it on Monday	Keep you current	Tell you what to improve

The other three can all be completed without a single lesson changing. Only the first column is defined by the change itself, which is why hours attended is a measure of the wrong thing.

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Mr Naeem has taught Class 7 mathematics for five years. In that time he has attended eleven in-service workshops, because attendance is recorded and the district requires a minimum.

He can tell you the titles. He has the certificates in a folder. Ask him what he does differently in a lesson because of any of them and he will, honestly, have no answer.

He is not a bad teacher and he was not inattentive at the workshops. The eleven certificates are an accurate record of eleven days spent. They are not a record of any development, and the difference between those two things is what this topic is about.

Explanation

What continuous professional development means

Continuous professional development is the ongoing process by which a professional maintains and extends the knowledge, judgement and skill their work requires, across a whole career rather than at its start.

The figure above sets it beside three things it is routinely confused with, and the distinctions matter practically.

A training course is an event. It has a start, an end and a certificate. It may contribute to development and it is not development, in the same way that buying a textbook is not reading it.

A qualification certifies that a threshold was met at a point in time. Unit 4's certification material applies: it answers "was this person prepared", past tense.

An appraisal requirement is an obligation imposed by an employer. It may prompt development and its natural product is compliance, as Unit 4's account of mixed purposes explained.

Continuing development differs from all three on the same axis: it is **driven by the practitioner**, it is **continuous rather than episodic**, and its measure is **a change in what you actually do**, not attendance, certification or compliance.

That last point disposes of Mr Naeem's folder. Eleven certificates measure eleven attendances. Guskey (2000), writing about how professional development should be evaluated, argues that evaluation must reach beyond participants' satisfaction and even beyond what they learned, to whether their practice changed and whether pupils' outcomes changed. Most systems stop at the first level, because satisfaction is the easiest thing to measure. Unit 4's warning about indicators that are easy to check applies exactly here.

A misconception to name at once: **professional development means attending a workshop**. It is the commonest belief in the field, it is what produces Mr Naeem's folder, and the rest of this unit is an argument against it.

The need for continuous professional learning and development

Why is this obligatory rather than admirable? Four reasons, and the first two are the ones a sceptical trainee will accept.

The knowledge base changes. What is known about how pupils learn, what the curriculum requires and what the examination demands all move. A teacher working from what they were taught in 2026 will, by 2040, be teaching from a settled picture that is no longer the picture.

Your pupils change. The intake shifts, languages shift, what children arrive knowing shifts. Unit 5's multilingual and multi-grade material is a live example: a method that worked for one cohort does not transfer unexamined.

Initial preparation cannot be sufficient, by construction. A B.Ed is three or four years against a career of thirty. No initial preparation in any profession attempts completeness; it attempts a foundation plus the capacity to keep learning. Unit 1's account of specialised knowledge as a mark of a profession implies this directly: a profession whose members stopped learning would have a static knowledge base, which is a trade rather than a profession.

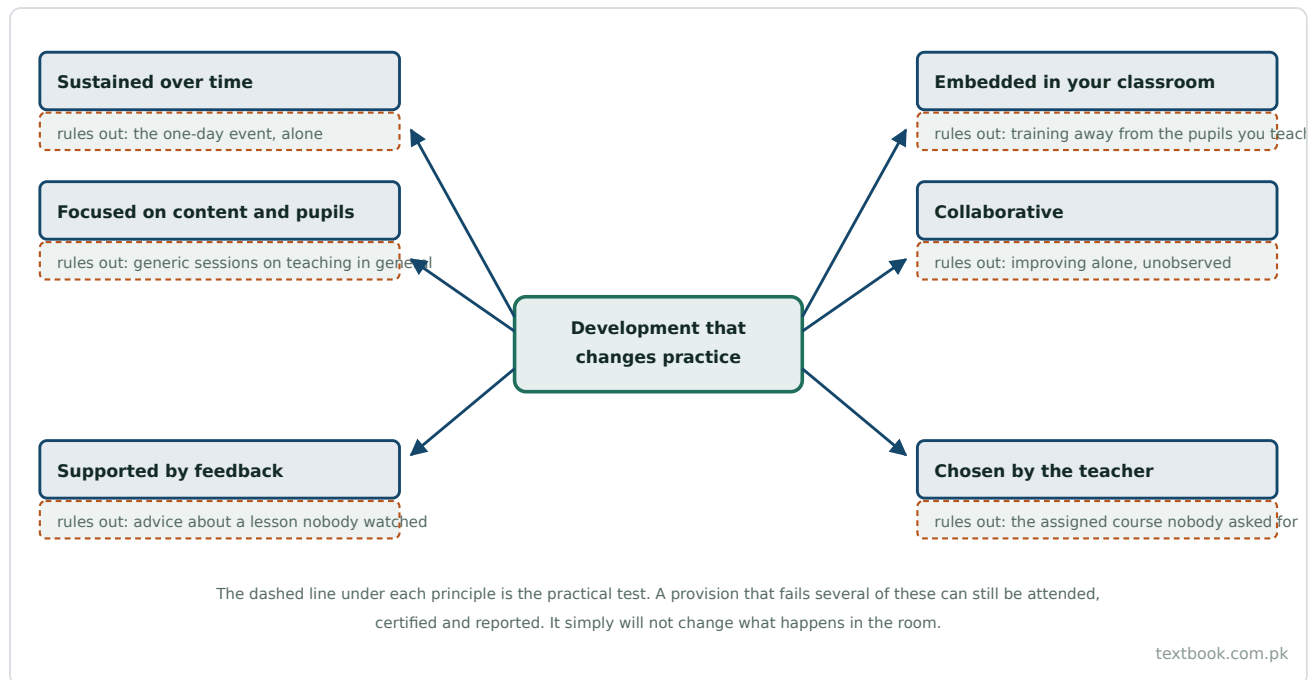
And the alternative is not stability but drift. This is the reason teachers underestimate. A practice that is not examined does not stay the same; it slowly adapts to convenience. Marking gets lighter, explanations get shorter, the same three pupils answer every question. Nobody decides any of it.

Kwakman (2003) studied what makes teachers participate in professional learning activities, which is the right question: participation is not automatic even when opportunity exists, and understanding why is more useful than exhorting people to develop. Note that this unit cites that work only for the question it asks; its abstract was not available when this unit was written, so no finding from it is claimed here.

Two things should be said plainly about the Pakistani context. Much available in-service provision is of the kind Mr Naeem attended: one-day, generic, delivered to a hall. And the structural supports that make development easy elsewhere, protected time, a subject specialist to ask, a library, are frequently absent, as

Unit 5 described. Both are true. Neither removes the obligation, and Topic 6.3 is built around what is available rather than what should be.

Principles of professional development



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The figure above states the principles as branches and, more usefully, names what each one rules out. The international review literature on teacher development, including Villegas-Reimers' survey for UNESCO's International Institute for Educational Planning (2003), converges on a recognisable set.

Sustained over time. Development that changes practice happens over months, not in a day. This rules out the one-day event as a complete intervention, which is most of what is offered.

Embedded in your own classroom. The gap between knowing a technique and using it with your Class 7 on a Tuesday is where most development dies. This rules out development that never touches your actual room.

Focused on specific content and specific pupils. "Improving questioning" is too general to act on; "getting the back three rows to answer in Class 7 mathematics" is not. This rules out the generic workshop.

Collaborative. Development done alongside colleagues persists, because the colleagues remain after the event ends. This rules out the individual attending alone and returning to a staffroom with no shared vocabulary for what they learned.

Supported by feedback on real practice. Someone has to see what you actually do. This rules out development that consists entirely of being told things.

Chosen rather than assigned. A teacher developing something they identified will persist through difficulty; a teacher sent on a course will not. Unit 4's separation of development from appraisal is the same principle from the other side.

Read those six against Mr Naeem's eleven workshops and the result is immediate: generic, one-day, off-site, individual, assigned, with no follow-up and no observation of his practice. His folder is not evidence of a lazy teacher. It is evidence of a provision that violates every principle at once, and it is what most in-service provision looks like.

The practical consequence is not to refuse what is offered. It is to know what a given activity can and cannot do, which is Topic 6.3, and to supply the missing principles yourself where you can, which is Topic 6.4.

Activity: Audit an offering

Work in groups of three. Take a real professional development activity that someone in the group has attended or heard described, in any subject.

Score it against the six principles: for each, is it satisfied, partly satisfied, or absent?

Then answer two questions. Which principles could have been added cheaply, without changing the activity itself? And which of those could a participating teacher have supplied for themselves, without anyone's permission?

Allow 25 minutes. The second question is the one that matters, and it usually produces at least two answers nobody had considered.

Check your understanding

1. Distinguish continuing professional development from a training course, a qualification and an appraisal requirement. (*Understand*)
2. Explain why eleven certificates are not evidence of development, using what evaluation should reach beyond. (*Apply*)
3. Give four reasons continuing development is an obligation rather than an optional extra. (*Remember*)
4. Explain what is meant by saying the alternative to development is drift rather than stability. (*Understand*)
5. Name the six principles, and for any three state what that principle rules out. (*Remember*)
6. Score Mr Naeem's workshops against the principles and explain what his folder actually demonstrates. (*Analyze*)

Summary

Continuing professional development is the ongoing process by which a professional maintains and extends the knowledge, judgement and skill the work requires. It is not a training course, which is an event; not a qualification, which certifies a past threshold; and not an appraisal requirement, which produces compliance. It is driven by the practitioner, continuous, and measured by a change in practice rather than by attendance.

It is obligatory rather than admirable for four reasons: the knowledge base changes, the pupils change, initial preparation cannot be complete by construction, and the alternative to examined practice is not stability but drift toward convenience.

Development that changes practice is sustained, embedded in the teacher's own classroom, focused on specific content and pupils, collaborative, supported by feedback on real practice, and chosen rather than assigned. Most available provision violates all six at once, which explains a folder of certificates and no change in teaching.

Self-assessment checklist

Sign in to sync your ticks across devices.

- ☐ I can distinguish development from training, qualification and appraisal.
- ☐ I can explain why attendance is a poor measure and say what a better one reaches.
- ☐ I can give four reasons development is obligatory, including drift.
- ☐ I can name the six principles and what each rules out.
- ☐ I can audit a real offering against the principles and say which I could supply myself.

Try this at your practicum school

Ask three teachers in your practicum school two questions: what professional development they have attended in the last two years, and what they do differently because of it.

Write half a page on the gap between the two answers. Be careful with the framing: this is not an audit of whether they are good teachers, and if it is heard that way you will get defensive answers and learn nothing. The honest framing is that you are trying to find out what kind of development actually works, and their experience is your evidence.

Summative task

Write 400 to 450 words.

Mr Naeem has eleven certificates and no change in practice. Diagnose why, and design a single development activity for him that satisfies as many of the six principles as a real Pakistani government school could support.

Your answer must score his existing provision against the principles, identify which failures are the provider's and which are his, and design something specific. Address the objection that your design requires time and colleagues that his school does not have.

Mini-rubric

Criterion	What a strong response does
Use of the principles (Apply)	Scores the existing provision against all six, not a selection
Attribution of failure	Separates what the provider failed to supply from what he failed to supply himself
Design (Create)	Specific enough to start on Monday, and satisfies principles the existing provision violated
Answering the constraint (Evaluate)	Engages with the real absence of time and colleagues, and designs within it rather than assuming it away

Further reading

- Guskey, T. R. (2000). *Evaluating professional development*. Corwin Press. On why evaluation must reach past satisfaction to changed practice and pupil outcomes.
- Villegas-Reimers, E. (2003). *Teacher professional development: An international review of the literature*. UNESCO IIEP.
<https://unesdoc.unesco.org/ark:/48223/pf0000133010>
- Kwakman, K. (2003). Factors affecting teachers' participation in professional learning activities. *Teaching and Teacher Education*, 19(2), 149-170.
[https://doi.org/10.1016/S0742-051X\(02\)00101-4](https://doi.org/10.1016/S0742-051X(02)00101-4) Cited here for the question it asks; no finding from it is claimed in this topic.

Tip: select any text on this page first to comment on that specific passage - or leave nothing selected for general feedback.

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